

U.S. DEPARTMENT OF AGRICULTURE
WASHINGTON, D.C. 20250

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SUBJECT: Media Protection	DATE: May 19, 2026
OPI: Office of the Chief Information Officer, Cybersecurity and Privacy Operations Center	EXPIRATION DATE: May 19, 2031

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1. PURPOSE

- a. This Departmental Regulation (DR) establishes the United States Department of Agriculture’s (USDA) policy for protecting all forms of media that record and store digital or nondigital information.
- b. USDA complies with Federal requirements to establish, implement, and enforce media protection policies and procedures.
- c. This DR provides the basis for USDA Mission Areas, agencies, and staff offices to develop and implement media protection procedures that outline how to:
 - (1) Access digital and nondigital media, based on the data’s sensitivity;

- (2) Protect USDA personnel, missions, and processes against malicious or unauthorized activities; and
- (3) Protect the confidentiality and integrity of USDA data.

2. SCOPE

This DR applies to all:

- a. USDA personnel working for, or on behalf of, USDA. The term “USDA personnel” encompasses USDA employees, appointees, contractors, partners, interns, fellows, affiliates, and volunteers;
- b. Federal information, per [DR 3080-001](#), *Records Management*, in any medium or form generated, collected, provided, transmitted, stored, maintained, or accessed by or on behalf of USDA; and
- c. Information systems or services (including cloud-based services) used or operated by USDA, USDA contractors, or other organizations on behalf of, or funded by, USDA and interconnections between or among systems or services.

3. SPECIAL INSTRUCTIONS/CANCELLATIONS

- a. This policy supersedes the previous version of DR 3445-001, *Media Protection*, dated October 30, 2019.
- b. This policy is effective immediately. It remains in effect until superseded or expired.
- c. Nothing in this policy alters the requirements for protecting national security systems or information. This includes the requirements identified in:
 - (1) The *Federal Information Security Modernization Act of 2014* (FISMA), [44 United States Code \(U.S.C.\) § 3551, et seq.](#), *SUBCHAPTER II—Information Security*;
 - (2) The [Committee on National Security Systems](#) (CNSS) policies, directives, instructions, and standards; and
 - (3) Intelligence community policies, directives, and instructions.
- d. This DR does not deal with classified or Classified National Security Information (CUI). CUI is sensitive information that does not meet the criteria for classification but still requires protection.
- e. This policy is closely related to other USDA policies, programs, and procedures, including:
 - (1) [DR 3080-001](#), *Records Management*;

- (2) [DR 3440-001](#), *USDA Classified National Security Information Program*;
 - (3) [DR 3440-003](#), *Controlled Unclassified Information (CUI) Program*;
 - (4) [DR 3515-002](#), *Privacy Policy and Compliance for Personally Identifiable Information (PII)*;
 - (5) [DR 3185-004](#), *Enterprise Zero Trust Architecture*;
 - (6) [DR 3530-007](#), *Encryption Security and Public Key Infrastructure*;
 - (7) [DR 3580-004](#), *Securing Remote Access to USDA Information Systems and Client Devices*;
 - (8) [DR 3580-005](#), *Securing Client Devices for International Travel*; and
 - (9) [DR 3640-001](#), *Identity, Credential, and Access Management*.
- f. All USDA Mission Areas, agencies, and staff offices will align their media protection procedures with this DR within 6 months of the publication date.

4. BACKGROUND

- a. Digital and nondigital media provide ways of recording and storing information and exist in a variety of formats.
 - (1) Digital media can be:
 - (a) Magnetic, such as disks or tapes;
 - (b) Optical, such as optical discs, such CDs or DVDs; and
 - (c) Nonvolatile storage, such as thumb drives, external hard drives, and portable data cards.
 - (2) Examples of nondigital media include paper documents and microfilm.
- b. Media is portable; easy to conceal; and easily misplaced, lost, or stolen. Protecting media reduces the risk of:
 - (1) Unauthorized data exposure (loss of confidentiality);
 - (2) Data tampering (loss of integrity); or
 - (3) Inability to access data when needed (loss of availability).

5. POLICY

Mission Areas, agencies, and staff offices will:

- a. Protect and control access to all types of media and information used by, or on behalf of, USDA;
- b. Create, update, and maintain processes and procedures that reflect policy consistent with other USDA policies and procedures related to records management;
- c. Ensure that all media are protected throughout their lifecycle and wherever located, whether in use, in storage, in transport, or during maintenance;
- d. Define appropriate use for trusted and untrusted USDA removable media;
- e. Prevent untrusted removable digital media from being used on devices owned or operated by, or on behalf of, USDA, by using automated mechanisms;
- f. Encrypt, when necessary, all government-issued digital media storage devices, per [DR 3530-007](#);
- g. Encrypt all non-publicly available Federal information residing on USDA removable digital media and client devices when taken outside of USDA facilities, when required. See National Institute of Standards and Technology (NIST) [Federal Information Processing Standards Publication \(FIPS PUB\) 140-2](#), *Security Requirements for Cryptographic Modules*. Also see NIST [Special Publication \(SP\) 800-111](#), *Guide to Storage Encryption Technologies for End User Devices*;
- h. Specify other technical safeguards, such as requirements to:
 - (1) Scan media for malicious code regularly or prior to use;
 - (2) Disable or remove the ability to insert, read, or write to media. Alternatively, configure removable digital media ports to “read only” and disable “read, write, execute” capabilities;
 - (3) Protect media containing PII (e.g., media encryption, password protection, logging, and secure transport) per [DR 3515-002](#);
 - (4) Ensure all media, including client devices, taken on international travel comply with the requirements in [DR 3580-005](#);
 - (5) Dispose of all nondigital media containing non-publicly available Federal information (e.g., shredded, burned), consistent with [National Archives and Records Administration](#) (NARA)-approved records retention schedules; and

- i. Develop, disseminate, and implement media protection procedures that:
 - (1) Identify both digital and nondigital media to be protected;
 - (2) List the types of media or devices authorized to store USDA information;
 - (3) Define restrictions on uses of media or activities with media (e.g., transport or use on non-USDA systems) and the circumstances of the restrictions;
 - (4) Identify and describe roles and responsibilities for media protection activities.
- j. Specify physical and logical discretionary and nondiscretionary access control methods for protecting access to different types of media;
- k. Specify acceptable methods and locations for securely storing the various types of media throughout the media's lifecycle. Specify acceptable methods for restricting access to stored media containing non-publicly available Federal information. This includes, but is not limited to, media stored at:
 - (1) Facilities owned or operated by, or on behalf of, USDA; and
 - (2) Primary or alternate storage locations for contingency and disaster planning purposes. [DR 3571-001](#), *Information System Contingency Planning and Disaster Recovery Planning*, addresses the frequency and quality of digital information stored at alternate storage sites.
- l. Specify acceptable methods for protecting and controlling different types of media (including non-digital media like microfilm or paper), during transport outside of controlled areas. Compare the information stored on the media with the following requirements:
 - (1) Authorize transport of media and the circumstances for doing so (i.e., business needs);
 - (2) Maintain accountability for, and tracking of, media throughout the transport process or a system to prevent or detect loss or misuse;
 - (3) Identify acceptable protection methods, both technical and physical. These can include encryption, packaging, or locked containers to prevent unauthorized access, destruction, or tampering;
 - (4) Identify cryptographic mechanisms to protect non-publicly available information stored on digital media during transport; and
 - (5) Indicate restrictions on transport methods (e.g., in personal vehicles) or destinations (e.g., outside the United States). Transportation of media will be in accordance with [DR 3515-002](#).

- m. Refer to DR 3080-001 or the NARA-approved records retention schedule to identify digital and nondigital media preservation requirements for information that is released for disposition. Apply the necessary requirements for the transfer of permanent historical records and the migration or destruction of temporary records; and
- n. Specify requirements to sanitize media prior to their disposal, release out of organizational control, or release for reuse. Ensure that digital media are sanitized prior to redeployment, maintenance, decommissioning, or disposal. This will include:
 - (1) Employing sanitization mechanisms with the strength and integrity commensurate with the types of information residing on the media;
 - (2) Ensuring that unauthorized users do not obtain access to data stored by the previous user.
 - (3) Describing the sanitization techniques and procedures to be employed, per NIST [SP 800-88](#), Revision 1, *Guidelines for Media Sanitization*; and
 - (4) Reviewing the specific requirements for media containing data from information systems categorized as high impact. Use the standards for high impact specified in NIST, [FIPS PUB 199](#), *Standards for Security Categorization of Federal Information and Information Systems*. These requirements will include:
 - (a) Reviewing, approving, tracking, documenting, and verifying media sanitization and disposal actions;
 - (b) Testing sanitization equipment and reviewing procedures at least annually, to verify that the intended sanitization is being achieved; and
 - (c) Defining circumstances for nondestructive sanitization techniques for portable digital media storage before connecting them to an information system.

6. ROLES AND RESPONSIBILITIES

- a. The USDA Chief Information Officer (CIO) will:
 - (1) Be the senior agency official responsible for media protection; and
 - (2) Ensure the Department's media protection and sanitization goals are aligned with business objectives and risk management practices.
- b. The USDA Chief Privacy Officer (CPO) will:
 - (1) Provide oversight and guidance on PII issues; and
 - (2) Coordinate with System Owners and Data Stewards to:

- (a) Ensure acceptable methods of protecting, controlling, and securing information; and
 - (b) Ensure appropriate oversight before sanitizing information or media
- c. The Departmental Records Officer will:
 - (1) Provide oversight and guidance on Federal and Departmental requirements for related records management and retention issues; and
 - (2) Coordinate with System Owners and Data Stewards to:
 - (a) Ensure acceptable methods of protecting, controlling, and securing information; and
 - (b) Ensure appropriate oversight before sanitizing information or media.
- d. Office of Homeland Security (OHS) will advise USDA personnel on matters relating to data that is classified when compiled.
- e. The USDA Chief Information Security Officer (CISO) will:
 - (1) Ensure that the Department's information security program and plans adequately address media protection. Ensure that personnel update the information security program and plans accordingly, as Federal requirements for media protection change; and
 - (2) Provide compliance oversight and guidance to Mission Areas, agencies, and staff offices on Federal and Departmental requirements for media protection.
- f. Mission Area Assistant CIOs will:
 - (1) Ensure that procedures for media protection are developed, implemented, and updated as needed and that they comply with Federal and Departmental requirements; and
 - (2) Ensure that all personnel are aware of media protection requirements.
- g. Mission Area Assistant CISOs and Information Systems Security Managers (ISSM) will:
 - (1) Coordinate with the USDA CPO, Departmental Records Officer, OHS Director, System Owners and Data Stewards to:
 - (a) Ensure acceptable methods of protecting, controlling, and securing information are in place before sanitizing information or media; and
 - (b) Ensure appropriate procedures and safeguards are in place before sanitizing information or media.

- (2) Develop, disseminate, and update agency procedures for media protection;
- (3) Ensure that rules of behavior include media protection requirements; and
- (4) Provide oversight and guidance on compliance with all media protection requirements.

h. Data Stewards will:

- (1) Coordinate with System Owners to assign roles and define responsibilities for marking, protecting, and securely storing information or media;
- (2) Review agency media protection procedures. Ensure requirements address procedural gaps. Provide instructions for agency personnel on how to implement and follow the procedures;
- (3) Ensure media protection procedures address requirements for protecting any media which:
 - (a) Contain PII;
 - (b) Are transported outside of USDA-controlled facilities; or
 - (c) Are being taken on, or returning from, international travel.
- (4) Coordinate with System, Database, and Network Administrators to ensure that media are properly sanitized prior to disposal, release out of organizational control, or release for reuse.

i. System Owners will:

- (1) Document media protection lifecycle requirements as part of their system security plans (SSP), including but not limited to:
 - (a) Appropriate levels of protection based on the types of information (e.g., per non-publicly available information) stored on various types of media;
 - (b) Backup media and transport to alternate storage; and
 - (c) Roles and responsibilities, including but not limited to, marking media and media sanitization.
- (2) Ensure that media for their systems are properly marked, stored, and transported; and
- (3) Verify through the Office of the General Counsel that the media and information are not subject to electronic discovery litigation or other legal requirements or restrictions prior to sanitizing, disposing of, or destroying the media.

- j. System, Database, and Network Administrators will:
 - (1) Comply with all Federal and Departmental media protection requirements and rules of behavior included in the Information Security Awareness Training course;
 - (2) Properly mark all system media, as applicable; and
 - (3) Ensure that media are properly sanitized prior to disposal, release out of organizational control, or release for reuse.
- k. All USDA personnel will:
 - (1) Complete the annual Information Security Awareness Training course, which includes many aspects of media protection, in accordance with [DR 3545-001](#), *Information Security Awareness (ISA) Program*;
 - (2) Comply with all Federal and Departmental media protection requirements and rules of behavior included in the Information Security Awareness Training course;
 - (3) Follow documented procedures for using, storing, and transporting digital and non- digital media;
 - (4) Promptly report lost or stolen digital or nondigital media, per incident reporting policy and procedures; and
 - (5) Report misuse or abuse of media to appropriate authorities.

7. PENALTIES AND DISCIPLINARY ACTIONS FOR NONCOMPLIANCE

- a. Responsibilities and conduct, in regard to using computers and telecommunication equipment, appear in [DR 4070-735-001](#), *Employee Responsibilities and Conduct, Section 16, Computers*.
- b. In addition, DR 4070-735-001, Section 21, *Disciplinary or Adverse Action*, states:
 - (1) Any violation of the responsibilities or standards contained in this DR may be cause for disciplinary or adverse action; and
 - (2) Any disciplinary or adverse action taken will be consistent with the applicable laws and regulations.

8. POLICY EXCEPTIONS

- a. All Mission Areas, agencies, and staff offices will conform to this policy.

- b. Any Mission Area, agency, or staff office that cannot meet a specific policy requirement must request a policy exception via email. Contact the Office of the Chief Information Officer (OCIO) Cybersecurity and Privacy Operations Center (CPOC) Security Management Division (SMD) Risk Management Branch at POAMProgram@usda.gov. An approved policy exception is an acceptance of risk but does not constitute compliance.

9. INQUIRIES

Send any questions or concerns about this DR to OCIO CPOC via CPOC-CyberPolicy@usda.gov.

-END-

APPENDIX A

ACRONYMS AND ABBREVIATIONS

CFR	Code of Federal Regulations
CIO	Chief Information Officer
CISO	Chief Information Security Officer
CNSS	Committee on National Security Systems
CNSSI	Committee on National Security Systems Instruction
CPO	Chief Privacy Officer
CPOC	Cybersecurity and Privacy Operations Center
CS	Cybersecurity
CUI	Controlled Unclassified Information
DM	Departmental Manual
DR	Departmental Regulation
E.O.	Executive Order
FIPS PUB	Federal Information Processing Standards Publication
FISMA	Federal Information Security Modernization Act
ISSM	Information Systems Security Manager
KEK	Key Encryption Key
LSI	Large-Scale Integration
MEK	Media Encryption Key
NARA	National Archives and Records Administration
NIST	National Institute of Standards and Technology
OCIO	Office of the Chief Information Officer
OHS	Office of Homeland Security
OMB	Office of Management and Budget
PII	Personally Identifiable Information
P.L.	Public Law
SBU	Sensitive but Unclassified
SMD	Security Management Division
SOP	Standard Operating Procedure
SP	Special Publication
SSP	System Security Plan
U.S.C.	United States Code
USDA	United States Department of Agriculture

APPENDIX B

DEFINITIONS

Clear. A method of sanitization by applying logical techniques to sanitize data in all user-addressable storage locations for protection against simple non-invasive data recovery techniques using the same interface available to the user; typically applied through the standard read and write commands to the storage device, such as by rewriting with a new value or using a menu option to reset the device to the factory state (where rewriting is not supported). (Source: NIST SP 800-88, Revision 1)

Cryptographic Erase. Method of sanitization in which the Media Encryption Key (MEK) for the encrypted Target Data (or the Key Encryption Key (KEK)) is sanitized, making recovery of the decrypted Target Data infeasible. (Source: CNSS [CNSSI 4009](#), *Committee on National Security Systems (CNSS) Glossary*)

Cryptography. Art or science concerning the principles, means, methods for rendering plain information unintelligible and for restoring encrypted information to intelligible form. (Source: CNSS CNSSI 4009)

Controlled Unclassified Information (CUI). Information that requires safeguarding or dissemination controls pursuant to and consistent with applicable law, regulations, and governmentwide policies but is not classified under E.O. 13526, Classified National Security Information, or the Atomic Energy Act, 42 U.S.C. § 2011, as amended. (Source: E.O. 13556, Controlled Unclassified Information)

Cybersecurity (CS). Prevention of damage to, protection of, and restoration of computers, electronic communications systems, electronic communications services, wire communication, and electronic communication, including information contained therein, to ensure its availability, integrity, authentication, confidentiality, and nonrepudiation. (Source: CNSS CNSSI 4009)

Data Steward. Individual or group that helps to ensure the careful and responsible management of Federal information belonging to the Nation as a whole, regardless of the entity or source that may have originated, created, or compiled the information. Data stewards provide maximum access to Federal information to elements of the Federal Government and its customers, balanced by the obligation to protect the information in accordance with the provisions of FISMA and any associated security-related federal policies, directives, regulations, standards, and guidance. (Source adapted from: NIST Computer Security Resource Center, [Glossary](#))

Destroy. A method of sanitization that renders target data recovery infeasible using state-of-the-art laboratory techniques and results in the subsequent inability to use the media for storage of data. (Source: NIST SP 800-88, Revision 1)

Encryption. Any procedure used in cryptography to convert plain text into cipher text to prevent anyone but the intended recipient from reading that data. (Source: NIST [SP 800-101](#), Revision 1, *Guidelines on Mobile Device Forensics*)

Federal Information. Information created, collected, processed, maintained, disseminated, or disposed of by, or for, the Federal Government in any medium or forum. (Source: Office of Management and Budget (OMB) [Circular A-130](#), *Managing Information as a Strategic Resource*)

Federal Information System. An information system used or operated by an executive Agency, by a contractor of an executive Agency, or by another organization on behalf of an executive Agency. (Source: NIST [SP 800-53](#), Revision 5, *Security and Privacy Controls for Information Systems and Organizations*)

Media. Physical devices or writing surfaces including, but not limited to, magnetic tapes, optical disks, magnetic disks, Large-Scale Integration (LSI) memory chips, and printouts (but not including display media) onto which information is recorded, stored, or printed within an information system. See also singular “Medium.” (Source: NIST SP 800-53, Revision 5)

Media Sanitization. The actions taken to render data written on media unrecoverable by both ordinary and extraordinary means. (Source: NIST SP 800-88, Revision 1)

Medium. Material on which data are or may be recorded, such as paper, punched cards, magnetic tape, magnetic disks, solid state devices, or optical discs. (Source: NIST SP 800-88, Revision 1)

Mobile Device. Small mobile computers such as smartphones and tablets which often run a mobile-specific OS such as Apple iOS and Google Android. Mobile devices are most often used for remote access methods that use web browsers, primarily SSL VPNs and individual web application access. (Source: NIST [SP 800-46](#), Revision 2, *Guide to Enterprise Telework, Remote Access, and Bring Your Own Device (BYOD) Security*)

Personally Identifiable Information (PII). Any information about an individual maintained by an Agency, including (1) any information that can be used to distinguish or trace an individual’s identity, such as name, social security number, date and place of birth, mother’s maiden name, or biometric records; and (2) any other information that is linked or linkable to an individual, such as medical, educational, financial, and employment information. (Source: NIST Computer Security Resource Center, *Glossary*)

Purge. A method of Sanitization by applying physical or logical techniques that renders Target Data recovery infeasible using state of the art laboratory techniques. (Source: NIST SP 800-88, Revision 1)

Removable Media. Portable data storage medium that can be added to or removed from a computing device or network. (Source: CNSS CNSSI 4009)

Sanitization. Actions taken to render data written on media unrecoverable by both ordinary and, for some forms of sanitization, extraordinary means. Process to remove information from media such that data recovery is not possible. It includes removing all classified labels, markings, and activity logs. (Source: NIST [SP 800-172A](#), *Assessing Enhanced Security Requirements for Controlled Unclassified Information*)

Sanitize. A process to render access to Target Data on the media infeasible for a given level of effort. Clear, Purge, and Destroy are actions that can be taken to sanitize media. (Source: NIST SP 800-88, Revision 1)

Storage. Retrievable retention of data. Electronic, electrostatic, or electrical hardware or other elements (media) into which data may be entered, and from which data may be retrieved. (Source: NIST SP 800-88, Revision 1)

Target Data. The information subject to a given process, typically including most or all information on a piece of storage media. (Source: NIST SP 800-88, Revision 1)

Trusted Removable Device. Ability to take organizationally defined actions when unauthorized hardware and software components are detected (e.g., disallow a flash drive to be connected even if a USB port is present). Ability to store the operating environment (e.g., firmware image, software, applications) in read-only media (e.g., Read Only Memory).

Untrusted Removable Device. Portable device that can be connected to an information system (IS), computer, or network to provide data storage. These devices interface with the IS through processing chips and may load driver software, presenting a greater security risk to the IS than non-device media, such as optical discs or flash memory cards.

Zero Trust. A collection of concepts and ideas designed to minimize uncertainty in enforcing accurate, least privilege per-request access decisions in information systems and services in the face of a network viewed as compromised. (Source: NIST [SP 800-207](#), *Zero Trust Architecture*)

APPENDIX C

AUTHORITIES AND REFERENCES

[5 Code of Federal Regulations \(CFR\) § 2635.101, et seq.](#), *Part 2635—Standards of Ethical Conduct for Employees of the Executive Branch*

[18 U.S.C. § 1028](#), *Fraud and related activity in connection with identification documents, authentication features, and information*

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USDA, [DR 3580-005](#), *Securing Client Devices for International Travel*, November 30, 2018

USDA, [DR 3640-001](#), *Identity, Credential, and Access Management*, June 8, 2021

USDA, [DR 4070-735-001](#), *Employee Responsibilities and Conduct*, October 4, 2007

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